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(AI-Generated Session Notes)

AI Adaptation: The People Side of Scale

Date & time: Oct. 14, 10:00-10:35 AM EST
Track: Strategic AI



Pam Boiros

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- LinkedIn

Session Description

Most marketing teams don’t struggle with AI because they chose the wrong tools. They struggle because AI changes how work gets done—roles, quality standards, decision rights, review cycles, and what “good” even looks like.

This session is for leaders at all levels who need to drive AI adaptation (not just adoption) across a team. We’ll unpack what has to shift after the pilot: building confidence and trust, turning scattered experimentation into repeatable workflows, reducing resistance without burning people out, and setting processes and guardrails that make AI safer and easier to use.

You’ll leave with a playbook you can use immediately: the five building blocks of AI adaptation (skills, workflows, guardrails, measurement, and culture), plus real examples from three years of training marketers and teams.

Key Quote

> *“AI is a team sport, so if people are just on their screen doing their work themselves, nobody is learning from that.”* **- Pam Boiros**

Session Summary

Pam Boiros, a fractional CMO, AI enablement and upskilling leader for B2B and tech marketing teams, and co-founder of the nonprofit community Women Applying AI, led this session on what it takes to move organizations from AI adoption to AI adaptation. She drew a clear line between the two: adoption is the introduction and use of tools, while adaptation is the deeper change in how people think, work, lead, collaborate, and create value.

Noting that nearly every hand in the room went up when she asked whose teams had broad AI access but wildly uneven usage, Boiros presented five interlocking building blocks for closing that gap: skills, guardrails, workflows, measurement, and culture. She emphasized that these blocks reinforce one another and that culture influences all of the others.

On skills, she argued that tool proficiency is table stakes and that the evergreen capabilities are uniquely human: problem framing, context building, critical evaluation, judgment and taste, curiosity, and accountability. She stressed that training creates awareness, but practice and sharing build adaptation. On guardrails, she described how good guidance creates permission

and clarity, sharing a client's simple data rule for Microsoft 365 Copilot and comparing guardrails to the barriers that let drivers take a mountain curve with confidence.

For workflows, Boiros used the story of her grandmother's chocolate chip cookies, which departed from the printed recipe in ways only careful observation revealed, to show how much hidden expertise lives inside everyday processes. She urged leaders to capture knowledge from the people closest to the work, use outsider reviews, and redesign before automating, since agentic AI will follow a recipe whether it is good or bad. On measurement, she called adoption metrics necessary but not sufficient, pointing instead to cycle time, quality and consistency, revenue and pipeline impact, and sustained behavior change, while warning against "work slop" that simply pushes burden downstream.

Closing on culture, she contrasted a supportive adaptation environment, led by a CMO who experiments publicly and defines success as a more creative and engaged team, with a fear-shaped environment where AI is mandated amid repeated layoffs. Her conclusion: stop managing AI like a tool rollout and start managing it as people change.

Key Takeaways

- **Adaptation is not adoption.** Rolling out tools is only the start; real value comes from changing roles, quality standards, workflows, and how people lead and collaborate.
- **Invest in evergreen human skills.** Problem framing, context building, critical evaluation, judgment, curiosity, and accountability will stay valuable even as tools and models change.
- **Make guardrails simple and enabling.** Clear, easy-to-remember rules about which tools and data people can use give them the confidence to move faster.
- **Redesign workflows before automating them.** Capture hidden expertise from the people doing the work, bring in an outsider review, and decide what AI handles and what stays human reserved.
- **Measure what changed, not just usage.** Look beyond licenses and active users to cycle time, quality, pipeline impact, and whether work was improved or simply pushed downstream.
- **Leaders shape the culture that determines success.** Modeling vulnerability, learning in public, rewarding judgment, and making it safe to say "I'm stuck" turns the same AI initiative into a far more successful one.